GUEST GUIDE · SATURDAY 24 OCTOBER 2026

*Linh & Huy*

# The engagement · *Lễ Ăn Hỏi*

**Saturday 24 October 2026**
14:15

**The bride's family home**
550 Trần Hưng Đạo Street, Phủ Lý Ward, Ninh Bình

The Lễ Ăn Hỏi is the formal marriage proposal. The groom's family goes in procession to the bride's family home, carrying trays of gifts, to ask for her hand — and you will walk in with them. It is a short, family-centred and highly codified ceremony that seals the bond between the two families before the next day's wedding.

**MEETING POINT**
2:15 pm in the lobby of the Melia Phủ Lý hotel. Contact point: Hà

**LENGTH**
Ceremony from 2:45 pm (about 1 h 30), then the reception from 4:30 pm

**DRESS**
Formal. Avoid all-white and all-black (colours of mourning)

**GIFT**
Nothing to bring or give on the day

> ***The gift trays (tráp)*** — Lacquered boxes covered in red silk, always in an odd number (5, 7 or 9). They hold betel leaves and areca nuts (trầu cau, a symbol of faithful love in Vietnamese legend), tea, liquor, fruit, rice cakes (bánh cốm, bánh phu thê, the "husband-and-wife cake") and red sticky rice (xôi gấc). Red brings luck.

## At the table

- Dishes are shared in the middle of the table. Wait for the elders to start, or to be invited to eat ("Mời!").
- Never stand your chopsticks upright in your rice: that gesture belongs to funeral rites.
- Feel free to move around and toast with other guests, then come back to your table. The uncles love to drink!
- Tip: learn a few Vietnamese toasts (see below) to fully enjoy the moment. A soft drink is fine too.

## Good to know

- Give and receive things (cup, glass, dish) with both hands.
- Greet the elders first.
- You may be asked to take your shoes off inside the house: wear shoes that slip off easily.
- Photos are welcome, but never in front of the altar during the rites.

## Weather & practical

- Late October in Ninh Bình: around 22–32 °C, humid, showers possible. Bring a light jacket and an umbrella.
- Keep some cash in Vietnamese dong (VND) on you.

## A few words & toasts

Rough pronunciation in brackets — any effort will be warmly appreciated!

**Xin chào** *(sin chow)*
Hello

**Cảm ơn** *(gahm uhn)*
Thank you

**Chúc mừng!** *(chook mung)*
Congratulations!

**Trăm năm hạnh phúc** *(chum num hahn fook)*
"A hundred years of happiness" — the classic wish to newlyweds

**Một, hai, ba, dzô!** *(mote, hi, ba, yo)*
"One, two, three, cheers!" — the classic toast

**Trăm phần trăm!** *(chum fun chum)*
"A hundred percent!" — bottoms up

**Chúc sức khỏe!** *(chook suk kweh)*
To your health!

**Ngon quá!** *(ngon kwah)*
Delicious!

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# What happens

**14:15** ● **Meet at the Melia Phủ Lý hotel**

Everyone travelling with the groom's family gathers in the hotel lobby. Your contact point for the day is Hà.

**YOUR PART** Please be on time: the group leaves together at 2:30 pm.

**14:30** ● **Departure for Linh's home**

The whole group leaves the hotel together for the bride's family home.

**YOUR PART** Stay with the group; Hà will guide you.

**14:40** ● **Arrival and forming the procession**

Outside the house, the group lines up: an elder who speaks for the family leads, followed by the parents, the groom and the young people carrying the gift trays.

**YOUR PART** Take your place behind the family and follow the line. A lovely moment to photograph.

**14:45** ● **Handing over the trays**

At the entrance, each tray bearer hands their tray, face to face, to a young woman from the bride's family. The bearers receive a small red envelope (lì xì) as thanks.

**YOUR PART** If you are one of the bearers, everything will be explained on the day: simply follow the person in front of you.

● **Introductions and the proposal**

The groom's family spokesperson introduces the family and formally asks for Linh's hand; the bride's family spokesperson replies. The speeches are in Vietnamese and last about ten minutes.

**YOUR PART** Sit where you are shown — seats near the stage are kept for the elders of both families. Please stay quiet and silence your phone.

● **Opening the trays, offering to the ancestors**

The trays are opened and some of the offerings are placed on the ancestral altar. The bride's parents light incense to announce the engagement to their ancestors.

**YOUR PART** Don't walk in front of the altar or touch the offerings.

● **The bride appears**

Linh, in an áo dài, comes in accompanied by her mother or a relative. Huy gives her a bouquet, then the couple serves tea to both families and together they light incense and bow at the altar.

**YOUR PART** Photo time! Follow the photographer's lead.

● **Returning the trays (lại quả)**

The bride's family gives back part of each tray's contents to the groom's family: luck is shared, never kept entirely. The families pose together for photos.

**YOUR PART** A good moment to congratulate the couple: "Chúc mừng!"

**16:30** ● **Reception**

A celebration meal is served. Dishes are placed in the middle of the table and shared, and toasts follow one another.

**YOUR PART** See "At the table" overleaf — and get your toasts ready!

*Trăm năm hạnh phúc*